

NOMAD

A SHORT FILM

A near-future thriller about the last man who can tell a person from a copy.

*A man goes looking for the friend who got out.
He finds the version of him that stayed behind.*

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The Story

NOMAD is a short film — roughly eighteen minutes — set close enough to now that nothing in it needs explaining. Synthetic video has become indistinguishable from real footage, except for a latency the eye learns to feel: a half-beat, four tenths of a second, landing in exactly the same place every time. Humans are never that consistent. In this world, paradise is usually a render.

WILL works identity verification. He audits the machine's fraud calls from a floor that emptied years ago — motion-sensor lights clicking on ahead of him like a runway for nobody, a coffee machine brewing a full pot at 8:55 so he can pour its only cup. He is the top human performer on a system that scores him 96.8 against its own 99.1, and he is very good at the one thing he is being eroded out of: knowing when a face isn't a person.

A year earlier his friend CAIRNS left — loudly, for a relocation service that handles everything for one fee. Since then Cairns calls from a pool somewhere warm, tanned and expansive and always about to disappear. The floor's last holdout is JOHN, who has never left the country, who runs a mini-putt course through the dead sales department, and who wants nothing more complicated than for his friends to be in the same room.

When the floor is closed for good, Will sells his face to the same service. He is scanned, filmed, and asked to describe his dream place. He answers honestly — high floor, light in the morning, somewhere I don't have to explain myself to anybody — and the camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

Abroad, in an apartment somebody was still moving out of, Will begins to notice. Cairns is warm, specific, and never quite available. On a street he passes a gaunt man working the curb, holding a phone up to strangers like ID: IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED — REFERENCE ON FILE. He sees him for one full second and steps around him.

Then a video call, and their old handshake — the dumb elaborate one, muscle memory — and the thing on the other end knows it, and lands one move wrong. Four seconds of Will fully awake.

He traces the calls to a building twenty minutes away. Upstairs: no pool, no paradise. Chairs, capture rigs, racks of scanned locations resold as somewhere else, and screen after screen of people at work who are not there. On one, his own welcome ad refining, saying things he has never said. From the next row, his own laugh — the real one.

The film ends where it has to. Will is declared synthetic by the system he served, tagged, and retained as a calibration reference — kept alive so the machine can go on being him accurately. And in a half-dismantled office on the other side of the world, John's laptop chimes with an incoming call, and the poolside frame fills the screen, and the audience recognises it before he does.

Form. Approx. 18 minutes. 22 scenes. Mostly behaviour; dialogue only where it earns the space.

Why now. Verification is quietly becoming the infrastructure of personhood — your face is your bank, your border, your job. NOMAD asks what happens when the reference model reads as more authentic than the person, and answers it in the smallest possible terms: two friends, a stupid handshake, and the one thing a dataset can never contain because nobody ever recorded it.

Achievable. A dying office floor, an apartment, a storefront, one server room. Small cast. The paradise is a render — which is the point, and the budget.